

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Using the following two primary sources, construct a document-based argument that analyzes how Pearl Harbor transformed American public opinion and government policy from isolationism to total war mobilization.

US.48 — Explain the progression of key events and President Franklin D. Roosevelt’s response to world crises that lead to U.S. entry into World War II, including the Quarantine Speech, the Four Freedoms Speech, the Atlantic Charter, the Lend-Lease Act, and Pearl Harbor.

US.49 — Analyze the response of the United States to the plight of European Jews before the start of the war, the U.S. liberation of concentration camps during the war, and the immigration of Holocaust survivors after the war.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

The sources

Document A

Excerpt from President Franklin D. Roosevelt's 'Day of Infamy' address to Congress, December 8, 1941 (National Archives, public domain)

“Yesterday, December 7th, 1941 — a date which will live in infamy — the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan... No matter how long it may take us to overcome this premeditated invasion, the American people in their righteous might will win through to absolute victory.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Excerpt from FDR's 'Four Freedoms' speech, January 6, 1941, nearly one year before Pearl Harbor
(National Archives, public domain)

“In the future days, which we seek to make secure, we look forward to a world founded upon four essential human freedoms... The fourth is freedom from fear — which, translated into world terms, means a world-wide reduction of armaments to such a point and in such a thorough fashion that no nation will be in a position to commit an act of physical aggression against any neighbor — anywhere in the world.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

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the audience do or think?

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does that shape it?

The question

Using SOAPS (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Significance) analysis for each document and your knowledge of U.S. foreign policy, analyze how Roosevelt's rhetoric evolved from January 1941 to December 1941, and evaluate what that evolution reveals about the political and strategic factors shaping U.S. entry into World War II. Include at least two pieces of outside evidence. Address the relationship between FDR's pre-Pearl Harbor rhetoric (Document B) and the formal isolationist legal framework he was navigating.

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Sophisticated thesis about FDR's rhetorical strategy across both documents. SOAPS applied accurately and fully to both documents. Two or more pieces of outside evidence. Analysis of the political constraints FDR navigated present. Synthesis of both documents into a cohesive argument about how Pearl Harbor functioned as political catalyst.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. Both documents analyzed with SOAPS (mostly complete). Two outside evidence pieces. Some synthesis present.
4	Proficient. Clear thesis. Both documents analyzed with at least three SOAPS elements each. One outside evidence piece. Argument present.
3	Adequate. Thesis present. One document fully analyzed, second partially. Some outside evidence. Argument partially developed.
2	Developing. Minimal thesis. Documents described but SOAPS not applied. Little outside evidence.
1	Beginning. No thesis. One document referenced. No analytical framework.
0	No response or completely off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: Doc A SOAPS — Speaker as wartime leader, occasion as day after attack, purpose as securing war declaration, significance as nation-transforming moment. Doc B SOAPS — Speaker as politically constrained president, occasion as pre-Pearl Harbor State of Union, purpose as building ideological groundwork, significance as revealing FDR's pre-war strategic thinking. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Neutrality Acts (1935–1937); Lend-Lease Act (March 1941); destroyers-for-bases agreement; America First Committee; 388-1 Congressional vote; Germany/Italy declaration of war (December 11, 1941).

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.